

ANCIENT SIEGE WARFARE

THE SIEGE OF LACHISH

By the 8th century BCE, the Assyrian empire had an army of unprecedented size and efficiency. Its assault on the fortified town of Lachish, recorded in reliefs in the Assyrian palace in Nineveh, demonstrated sophisticated, if well established, siege techniques and the calculated use of terror.

The army that King Sennacherib led to Judah in 701 BCE comprised a mixture of foot soldiers and mounted troops on chariots or on horseback. There was also a dedicated body of engineers, skilled in building earthworks and siege machines. The army's mission was to crush a revolt by the Judean King Hezekiah, and to impose exemplary punishment to deter any further resistance to Assyrian imperial rule.

The Assyrians' principal missile weapon was the composite bow. Capable of shooting an iron-tipped arrow to an effective range of over 250m (820ft), it was used by charioteers and horsemen, as well as by troops on foot. Assyrian foot soldiers also employed slingshots, flinging shaped stones a distance of 100m (330ft). Both of these were deadly anti-personnel weapons, and during a siege arrows could be turned into incendiary devices by dousing their tips in flammable pitch. Neither arrows nor small stones posed any threat to the high mud walls of Lachish, however, which presented a formidable challenge, even to an armed force that must have far outnumbered the defenders.

To force entry to a walled town, the Assyrian troops had to advance to the walls and find ways either to breach them or go over them. Assyrian engineers had developed a range of techniques for assailing fortifications. They could attack the foundations, digging at the base of the walls to undermine them; they could build a ramp against a wall or tower, allowing troops a route to the summit of the battlements; they could attack the walls with siege

towers and metal-tipped battering rams. Or, more simply, troops armed with spears and swords could be sent forward with ladders to scale the walls or fortifications.

SIEGE TOWER AND INFANTRY

At Lachish, engineers built a ramp of rocks and earth reaching to a point half way up the fortifications. At the same time they assembled a large siege tower, with a ram in its lower storey. Mounted on four wheels, the wooden tower was covered in hides and canvas. When the Assyrians were ready to attack, they manhandled the tower and ram up the ramp. While archers in the tower's upper storey shot at the defenders, soldiers battered the ram against the exposed wall. The defenders fought back against the assault, throwing rocks and flaming torches onto the tower, but the Assyrian soldiers kept water-filled buckets in the tower for extinguishing the resulting fires. Meanwhile, tightknit groups of soldiers on foot launched a secondary assault on the walls, armed with spears and protected by shields and armour. Assyrian bowmen supported this advance with a barrage of arrows directed at the defenders on the walls, each Bowman sheltered by a curved reed screen held by his shield-bearer.

The exact sequence of events leading to the fall of the town is not known, only that the Assyrians overcame the town's defences. The aftermath of this victory, depicted in reliefs for the king's enjoyment, involved the cruel execution of a large number of Judeans and the exile of the survivors.

